Key dates

Zionist conference decided on a policy of active opposition to British rule: 1945

Biltmore Declaration of support for a 'Jewish commonwealth' in all of Palestine: 1942

against the White Paper policy of 1939 that had opposed the idea of a separate Jewish state and sought to control immigration (see page 14). When the war ended in 1945 the British announced that there would be no change in their policy in Palestine: that is, there would be no big increase in immigration and no separate Jewish state. But the war had toughened the Zionists: six million Jews had been killed in the Nazi Holocaust and the Zionists were not in a mood to be patient. They were convinced that they had justice on their side and that international public opinion was coming round to support the idea of an independent Jewish state. In August 1945, the Zionist conference decided on a policy of active opposition to British rule in Palestine. Their leaders ordered the Haganah, the Jewish defence force, to co-operate with the **Irgun** and Stern gangs, two secret, underground Jewish organisations. British military bases, railways, trains and bridges in Palestine became the target of these terrorist groups.

Key question
Why was US support so important for the Zionists?

US support for a Jewish state

The Zionists also decided that the USA, not Britain, was now the country they needed to have on their side. Only the USA, one of the two superpowers that emerged after the war, could put enough pressure on Britain to agree to a separate Jewish state and leave Palestine. The Zionists had the support of the Jewish population in the USA who could, in turn, put pressure on the US government. There were four and a half million Jewish Americans, two million of them in New York city alone. By the end of the war, nearly all of them were Zionists, convinced of the need to establish an independent Jewish state for the Jewish refugees who had survived the Nazi Holocaust in Europe.

As early as May 1942, when news was only just beginning to emerge of the Nazi extermination of the Jews, the American Zionist conference had declared their support for a 'Jewish commonwealth' in *all* of Palestine. This became known as the Biltmore Declaration after the name of the hotel in New York in which the conference was held.

After the war, American Zionists, often joined by Jewish leaders from Palestine, launched a propaganda offensive: they addressed meetings, held rallies, placed advertisements and, above all, **lobbied** members of the US government and Congress, in order to win support. In April 1946, the US President, Harry Truman, called on the British government to allow the immediate entry of 100,000 Jewish refugees to Palestine. Six months later, he came out in support of the partition of Palestine.

Key terms

Irgun
A small secret Zionist organisation which fought for a Jewish state in all of Palestine.

Lobbied
To lobby is to win the support of members of a law-making body (e.g. the US Congress) so as to shape its policy.

Key question
Why and how did the Zionists resort to terrorism in Palestine?

Jewish terrorism

Meanwhile, in Palestine itself, the Zionists targeted the British. The reasons are not hard to see. The British authorities stopped boatloads of illegal Jewish immigrants from landing in Palestine. The British knew that Jewish immigration angered the Arabs and, when violence broke out between Jews and Arabs, British troops and police had to keep order. The British realised that further Jewish immigration would be resisted by the Arabs and lead to